

Miami Offshore Fishing Guide

435+ GPS Spots: Wrecks, Reefs, Artificial Reefs, and Ledges

From Miami Beach to Key Biscayne and Beyond

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Introduction

Miami is one of the few places on Earth where world-class offshore fishing is measured in minutes, not hours. The Gulf Stream pushes within 1 to 3 miles of the beach from Palm Beach south to Miami, creating a fishing highway unlike anything on the Atlantic coast. The combination of natural reef structure, hundreds of artificial wrecks, and the nutrient-rich current of the Gulf Stream means you can leave Government Cut at sunrise and be hooked up to a sailfish before your first cup of coffee gets cold.

This guide covers 435+ verified GPS fishing spots from Haulover Inlet south to Fowey Rocks and east into the Gulf Stream. Every coordinate in your download has been fished, verified, and cataloged with bottom type, depth, and target species. This is not a list scraped from the internet. These are real numbers from real time on the water.

Understanding Miami's Offshore Structure

The Reef Line

Miami's coast sits on the edge of the Florida Reef Tract, the only living coral barrier reef in the continental United States. The reef system runs roughly parallel to shore and creates three distinct ridges:

First Reef (60-80 feet): Runs about half a mile to three-quarters of a mile offshore. This is your bread-and-butter reef fishing territory. Yellowtail snapper, mutton snapper, hogfish, and smaller grouper hold along the first reef year-round. During lobster season, this is where the majority of recreational divers work, so expect traffic on weekends from mid-July through March.

Second Reef (80-110 feet): Sits roughly one to one-and-a-half miles offshore. The second reef has more vertical relief than the first and holds larger fish consistently. Black grouper, red grouper, and big mutton snapper camp on the second reef ledges. This is also a prime zone for cobia from November through March when they follow rays along the reef edge.

Third Reef (110-135 feet): The outside edge of the reef system, roughly two miles offshore. The third reef is where you start to see the transition from reef fish to pelagic species. Amberjack stack up on the high-profile spots, African pompano cruise the ledges, and during winter months, sailfish work the reef edge looking for ballyhoo schools.

The Edge and the Wall

Beyond the third reef, the bottom drops into a series of ledges and then falls away sharply into the Straits of Florida. The "edge" -- anywhere from 180 to 300 feet -- is prime territory for deepwater species: blackfin tuna, tilefish, queen snapper, and big amberjack. Several prominent ledges and drop-offs in this zone are included in your GPS package.

At 300-600 feet, the "wall" drops into the deep blue. This is where the Gulf Stream really rips, and where the big pelagic species hunt. Swordfish territory starts here for daytime drops, and wahoo cruise the current edges during winter.

Artificial Reefs and Wrecks

Miami-Dade County has one of the most aggressive artificial reef programs in the country. Over the decades, decommissioned ships, concrete culverts, reef balls, bridge rubble, and purpose-built structures have been deployed along the coast. Your GPS package includes coordinates for:

- **Named shipwrecks:** The Orion, Lakeland, Blue Fire, Deep Freeze, Rebel, Ultra Freeze, Jim Atria, Belzona Barge, and dozens more.
- **Numbered artificial reef sites:** Miami-Dade County's AR (Artificial Reef) numbered sites from AR-1 through AR-40+.
- **Bridge and construction rubble piles:** Material from the old Rickenbacker Causeway, I-395 demolition, and port expansion projects.
- **Reef ball deployments:** Engineered hollow concrete structures placed in permitted reef zones.

Many of these wrecks hold enormous populations of fish. A single large wreck like the Orion (a 200-foot freighter in 220 feet of water east of Key Biscayne) can hold hundreds of amberjack, schools of almaco jack, African pompano, and resident goliath grouper.

Target Species and When to Find Them

Sailfish (Peak: November through March)

Miami calls itself the Sailfish Capital of the World, and the claim is legitimate. The winter sailfish migration brings fish down from the Carolinas starting in late October, with peak numbers from December through February. The fish follow baitfish schools -- threadfin herring, ballyhoo, and pilchards -- south along the coast, riding the inside edge of the Gulf Stream.

Where to target: Most sailfish action happens in 90 to 180 feet of water along the reef edge and inside the Gulf Stream edge. Key areas include the stretch from Haulover Inlet south to Government Cut, the area east of Fisher Island, and the waters between the sea buoy and Fowey Rocks Light.

How to target: Kite fishing is king in Miami. The technique was pioneered here and has been refined over decades. Two or three kites deployed with live goggle eyes (bigeye scad) or pilchards suspended just below the surface is the most effective method. Slow-trolling live ballyhoo on 20-pound spin tackle is also deadly. During tournament season (December through March), the fleet typically runs between 100 and 200 boats on any given day from Haulover south.

Mahi-Mahi / Dolphinfish (Peak: March through July)

When the water temperature climbs into the mid-70s and current edges start pushing flotsam and weed lines inshore, the mahi show up. Spring and early summer bring the best mahi fishing, with fish ranging from schoolies (5-10 pounds) to tournament-quality bulls pushing 40-50 pounds.

Where to target: Mahi are pelagic -- they follow current edges, weed lines, and floating debris. Run east from Haulover or Government Cut until you find blue water (typically 3-10 miles depending on the Gulf Stream position), then hunt for color changes, birds, and structure. The GPS spots in deeper water (200+ feet) often attract mahi because baitfish stage around the wrecks.

How to target: Trolling small skirted ballyhoo, feathers, and Ilander-style lures covers water. When you find fish, stop and chunk cut bait to keep the school behind the boat. Light spinning tackle (15-20 pound) on live pilchards or small ballyhoo produces the best numbers.

Kingfish / King Mackerel (Peak: November through April)

Kingfish migrate through Miami in large numbers during the cooler months. Big smoker kings (30-60+ pounds) show up around Thanksgiving and stick around through early spring. They patrol the reef edge, especially around baitfish concentrations and wreck structure.

Where to target: First and second reef edges, especially near wrecks that hold baitfish. The stretch from Baker's Haulover to Government Cut is historically productive. Kings also stack up around Fowey Rocks and the offshore towers.

How to target: Slow-trolling live blue runners, goggle eyes, or threadfin herring on wire-leader kingfish rigs with a stinger hook. Flat-line one bait and run one off a downrigger at 40-60 feet. Drift fishing with live bait on a king mackerel rig (size 4/0 to 6/0 treble stinger) is also effective when you mark fish on the reef.

Amberjack (Year-round, Best: December through April)

Amberjack are the bruisers of the reef. Fish from 30 to over 100 pounds live on high-profile wrecks, artificial reefs, and prominent ledges in 100 to 250 feet of water. They are incredibly strong fighters -- pound for pound, few fish pull harder.

Where to target: The numbered artificial reef sites and named wrecks in your GPS package in 100-250 feet are your best bet. Amberjack are structure-oriented and rarely stray far from their home wreck. The Orion, Lakeland, Blue Fire, and the larger AR sites consistently hold big jacks.

How to target: Vertical jigging with heavy butterfly jigs (200-400 gram) is the most sporting method. Live bait (blue runners, goggle eyes) dropped to the bottom on 60-80 pound braid with a short fluorocarbon leader also produces well. Use heavy tackle -- these fish will bury you in the wreck if you let them.

Snapper (Year-round, Various Species)

Yellowtail Snapper: Year-round on the first and second reef. Best from October through April when water clears up. Anchor or drift over reef structure and chum with a mix of glass minnows, sand, and oats. Size 1 or 1/0 hooks on 15-20 pound fluorocarbon. Night fishing on the reef produces the largest yellowtails.

Mutton Snapper: Spawn on the full moons of May and June, concentrating on specific reef ledges in 60-120 feet. The spring mutton spawn is one of the most anticipated events on the Miami fishing calendar. Live pilchards on the bottom with a knocker rig or chicken rig in 60-90 feet during the full moon produces huge catches. The rest of the year, muttons are scattered on the reef and caught incidentally.

Mangrove Snapper: Abundant on wrecks, bridges, and channel edges. The best mangrove snapper fishing is often at night, anchored on a wreck in 60-100 feet with a chum bag and small live shrimp or pilchards on a knocker rig.

Vermillion Snapper (Beeliner): Deep reef edges and wrecks in 150-300 feet. Year-round but best in cooler months. Chicken rigs with squid strips or cut bonito produce limits.

Grouper (Season: May 1 through December 31 in Atlantic Federal Waters)

Black Grouper: The prized catch of the Miami reef. Blacks to 40+ pounds live on high-profile ledges and wrecks in 80-200 feet. Live blue runners, speedos, or pinfish on a knocker rig fished tight to structure. Heavy tackle required -- 50-80 pound braid minimum. These fish earn every inch you give them.

Red Grouper: More common in 80-150 feet on lower-profile structure. Live or dead bait on a knocker rig. Reds are less structure-dependent than blacks and are often caught on open sand near reef transitions.

Gag Grouper: Less common off Miami than further north, but gags do show up on deeper wrecks (150-250 feet), especially during cooler months. Vertical jigs and live bait.

Blackfin Tuna (Peak: November through March)

Blackfin tuna in the 10-30 pound range stage along the edge of the Gulf Stream in 200-400 feet. They're often found in mixed schools with bonito (false albacore). Live pilchard or goggle eye drifted in the current or trolled on small feathers and cedar plugs. Blackfin make exceptional sashimi -- many anglers consider them the best-eating tuna species.

Cobia (Peak: November through March)

Cobia migrate through Miami waters during winter, following spotted eagle rays along the reef edge. They also take up residence around channel markers, buoys, and crab trap floats. Sight-fishing for cobia on the reef with a live eel or live crab is the preferred method. They often cruise the surface and can be spotted from the tower or bow.

Swordfish (Year-round, Best: Full Moon Periods)

Miami is ground zero for the modern recreational daytime swordfishing revolution. The technique of deep-dropping baits (1,200 to 1,800 feet) for broadbill swordfish was developed here by anglers like RJ Boyle, Nick Stanczyk, and others. Your GPS package includes proven swordfish drop zones east of Miami in 1,000 to 2,000+ feet. Swordfishing is its own specialty -- dedicated heavy electric reel setups, large squid or belly strip baits, and specific rigging are required.

Seasonal Fishing Calendar Overview

Month	Primary Targets	Secondary Targets
January	Sailfish, Kingfish, Wahoo	Blackfin Tuna, Cobia, Swordfish
February	Sailfish, Kingfish, Cobia	Blackfin Tuna, Amberjack
March	Sailfish (late), Mahi (early), Kingfish	Cobia, Blackfin Tuna
April	Mahi-Mahi, Mutton Snapper (pre-spawn)	Kingfish (late), Amberjack
May	Mahi-Mahi, Mutton Snapper (spawn)	Yellowtail, Grouper (season opens)
June	Mahi-Mahi, Mutton Snapper (spawn)	Tarpon (inshore), Bonito
July	Mahi-Mahi (late), Snapper	Grouper, Mangrove Snapper
August	Snapper, Grouper	Blackfin Tuna (scattered), Bonito
September	Snapper, Grouper	Wahoo (early), Mahi (scattered)
October	Wahoo, Kingfish (early)	Sailfish (early), Snapper
November	Sailfish, Kingfish, Wahoo	Cobia, Blackfin Tuna, Amberjack
December	Sailfish, Kingfish	Wahoo, Blackfin Tuna, Swordfish

Techniques That Produce in Miami

Kite Fishing

Miami invented modern kite fishing for sailfish, and it remains the dominant technique for billfish, kingfish, and tuna on this coast. The basic setup: deploy one or two fishing kites from outrigger-mounted kite reels. Each kite supports two to three baits via release clips, suspending live baits (goggle eyes, pilchards, blue runners) at or just below the surface. The splash and struggle of the bait on the surface is irresistible to sailfish.

A proper kite spread uses spinning reels loaded with 20-pound braid, a 30-pound fluorocarbon leader, and a circle hook (5/0 to 7/0) through the nose of a live goggle eye. When a fish eats, free-spool until the line comes

tight, then engage the drag and let the circle hook set in the corner of the jaw.

Bottom Fishing on the Reef

The bread and butter of Miami reef fishing. Anchor or drift over your GPS-marked reef spots and send baits to the bottom. Two rigs dominate:

Knocker Rig: A sliding egg sinker resting directly on the hook eye, threaded on the leader above a swivel. Simple, effective, and keeps your bait right on the bottom where the grouper and snapper live. Use 40-60 pound fluorocarbon leader, an egg sinker heavy enough to hold bottom (2-6 oz depending on current), and a 5/0 to 7/0 circle hook.

Chicken Rig (High-Low Rig): Two hooks on dropper loops above a bank sinker. This rig is designed for multi-hook fishing in deeper water (100-300 feet) targeting yellowtail snapper, vermillion snapper, and porgy. Use 30-pound fluorocarbon, size 1/0 to 3/0 hooks, and tip with squid strips, sardine chunks, or cut bonito.

Trolling

For covering water and locating pelagic species. A basic Miami trolling spread runs four to six lines:

- **Flat lines (2):** Skirted ballyhoo or flounder lures on 30-50 pound class, fished 50-75 feet back.
- **Rigger lines (2):** Skirted ballyhoo on outrigger clips, fished 100-150 feet back.
- **Shotgun (1):** A deep-diving plug or feather run far back down the center, 200+ feet.
- **Optional downrigger or planer:** A diving bait run 30-60 feet deep for kingfish and wahoo.

Trolling speed for billfish and mahi: 6-8 knots. For wahoo: 8-12 knots with high-speed lures.

Live Bait Acquisition

Your fishing day in Miami starts at the bait. Knowing where and how to catch live bait is half the battle:

Pilchards (Scaled Sardines): The universal live bait of South Florida. Cast net them on the flats early morning -- look for dark patches of fish on sand flats near Haulover, along the Julia Tuttle Causeway, around the Venetian Causeway islands, and on the flats off Virginia Key. A 10-foot radius, 3/8-inch mesh cast net is standard.

Goggle Eyes (Bigeye Scad): The premium sailfish bait. Caught on sabiki rigs at night under lights at Haulover Inlet pier, along the Government Cut jetties, and off the reef in 90-130 feet. Bridge lights along the 79th Street Causeway and MacArthur Causeway also hold goggle eyes at night.

Ballyhoo: Caught on sabiki rigs over grass flats and shallow reef areas, or purchased frozen from local tackle shops. Frozen ballyhoo is the staple trolling bait.

Blue Runners (Hardtails): Caught on sabiki rigs or small hooks with cut bait around channel markers, bridge pilings, and artificial reefs. Excellent bait for amberjack, grouper, and large kingfish.

Local Knowledge: What the Charts Don't Tell You

Gulf Stream Position

The Gulf Stream is not a fixed highway. Its inner edge migrates inshore and offshore depending on seasonal patterns, wind, and larger oceanographic forces. In winter, the Stream often pushes tight to shore -- sometimes the blue water edge is visible from the beach, less than a mile out. In summer, the Stream can push out to 5-10 miles offshore.

Check sea surface temperature (SST) charts before every trip. NOAA's GOES satellite imagery and apps like Hilton's Realtime Navigator, FishWeather, and ROFFS show current Gulf Stream position and water temperature breaks. When you see a sharp temperature break from 73-degree green water to 78-degree blue water, that edge is where the fish concentrate.

Current and Drift Patterns

The Gulf Stream runs northward at 2-4 knots on average. When you are bottom fishing in 100+ feet and the current is ripping, you will need heavy weights (8-16 oz) or fish a drift rather than anchoring. Many experienced Miami captains drift-fish rather than anchor -- it covers more ground and keeps fresh structure under the boat.

The current is typically strongest on the outgoing tide, when the tidal flow adds to the Gulf Stream's northward push. Slack tide periods at the bottom of the outgoing or incoming cycle often produce the best bottom fishing because baits stay in the strike zone longer.

Weather Windows

South Florida weather patterns are predictable once you understand the seasonal cycles:

Winter (November-March): Cold fronts push through every 5-10 days. The best fishing is the 2-3 day window after a front passes, when winds switch from northwest to northeast and then settle into light east or southeast. The Gulf Stream calms down faster than the nearshore water after a front. Avoid the day of the front itself -- NW winds 20+ knots and steep, confused seas.

Summer (June-September): Morning calm gives way to afternoon thunderstorms almost daily. Plan your runs for early morning -- be offshore at first light, fish hard until noon, and be heading back before the afternoon storms build. Watch for squall lines developing to the west over the Everglades. When you see the anvil tops building, it is time to pull lines.

Transition Months (April-May, October): The best weather windows of the year. Light winds, calm seas, and warm water make these prime months for offshore trips. October in particular is underrated -- the crowds thin out, the water is still warm, and early-season kingfish and sailfish start showing up.

Running the Inlets

Haulover Inlet: The most heavily used fishing inlet in Miami. Notorious for its strong currents and short, steep waves on the outgoing tide, especially with an east wind. Check the Haulover Inlet webcam before running out. If you see white water stacking up in the cut, wait for the tide to turn or take it very slow. Stay center-channel and watch for cross-traffic from the sandbar snorkelers on the north side.

Government Cut: The main shipping channel into the Port of Miami. Wider and deeper than Haulover, and generally easier to navigate. Watch for cruise ships, container ships, and pilot boats. Commercial traffic has the right of way. Stay to the north side of the channel on your way out and monitor VHF Channel 16 and the Port of Miami traffic channel (Channel 14).

Bear Cut: Between Key Biscayne and Virginia Key. Shallow and winding with strong tidal currents. Only recommended for smaller boats with shallow draft. Local knowledge is essential here -- unmarked shoals shift with storms. Not recommended for first-timers.

Depth Zones and What to Expect

40-80 Feet: First Reef and Nearshore

This is your closest fishing ground, accessible to even small boats on calm days. Expect yellowtail snapper, mangrove snapper, lane snapper, small grouper (nassau, red, and juveniles), hogfish, porkfish, grunts, and occasional lobster-season traffic. This zone is also productive for night fishing during summer when mangrove snapper and yellowtail feed aggressively after dark.

80-135 Feet: Second and Third Reef

The meat of Miami's reef fishing. Black grouper, large mutton snapper, amberjack on the high spots, cobia cruising the ledges, and kingfish working the baitfish schools. Most of your included GPS spots fall in this zone because this is where the diversity and the quality of fish are highest.

135-250 Feet: Deep Reef and Wrecks

Big amberjack, almaco jack, African pompano, large black grouper, barracuda, and the occasional cobia or permit. The named wrecks in this depth range are the most productive single spots in the package. A single large wreck can produce a full cooler in a single stop if conditions are right.

250-600 Feet: The Edge

Blackfin tuna, queen snapper, tilefish, yellowedge grouper, snowy grouper, and barrel fish. This zone requires heavier tackle and longer drops but produces some unique eating fish that most anglers never target. Queen snapper in particular are one of the best-eating fish in the ocean -- bright red, white-fleshed, and almost always caught in deep water.

600+ Feet: Blue Water / Swordfish Territory

You're in the Gulf Stream proper. Trolling territory for mahi, wahoo, and marlin. Daytime swordfish drops start at 1,200 feet and go deeper. This is where your GPS swordfish spots come into play.

Your GPS Spot Categories

Your download is organized into the following categories for easy reference:

- **Natural Reef Spots:** Ledges, cuts, and high-profile sections of the three reef lines
- **Artificial Reef Sites:** Miami-Dade County numbered AR sites
- **Named Shipwrecks:** Verified wrecks with name, depth, and target species
- **Ledges and Drop-offs:** Deep water edges and transitions
- **Bait Spots:** Locations where live bait concentrates (pilchard flats, goggle eye marks, sabiki spots)
- **Sailfish Zones:** Proven kite fishing and live-bait drifting areas
- **Swordfish Drops:** Deepwater coordinates for daytime and nighttime swordfishing
- **Inlet and Channel Waypoints:** Navigation marks for safe entry and exit

Making the Most of Your Spots

Loading 435+ spots onto your chartplotter can be overwhelming if you try to fish them all at once. Here is a practical approach:

1. **Start with the spots closest to your home inlet.** If you run out of Haulover, focus on the Haulover-area spots first. If you launch from Black Point or Matheson Hammock, start with the Key Biscayne area spots.

2. **Pick a depth zone.** If you are a reef fisherman, focus on the 80-135 foot spots first. If you are a wreck fisherman, go to the named wrecks in 120-250 feet.

3. **Use the seasonal calendar.** In January, you should be on the sailfish spots. In May, you should be on the mutton snapper spots during the full moon. Match your GPS waypoints to what is biting.

4. **Mark your own waypoints around ours.** Our spots give you the starting coordinates. As you fish them, mark your own numbers around the spots where you find the best structure and the most fish. Over time, you will build a personal database that is dialed in to your exact style of fishing.

5. **Share spots carefully.** These coordinates are for your personal use. We understand that fishing is a social sport, but widespread sharing devalues the product and concentrates pressure on specific spots. Please respect the licensing terms.

Final Notes

The Miami offshore fishery is a world-class resource that produces incredible catches for anglers who put in the time to learn the water. Your GPS spots are a major shortcut -- they represent years of on-water experience compiled into a format you can load in minutes. But the spots are just the starting point. Pay attention to the conditions, learn the seasonal patterns, and respect the resource through proper fish handling and adherence to FWC regulations.

Tight lines and calm seas.

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